

What are Sifaat?

Sifaat (singular: sifa) are the characteristics that distinguish letters which share the same makhraj. A letter's sifa tells you HOW to pronounce it — heavy or light, voiced or whispered, strong or soft.

Heavy vs Light Letters

The most important sifa for Quran recitation:

Type	Letters	How to Pronounce
Always HEAVY (Mufakhhkam)	Saad, Daad, Taa, Zaa, Qaaf, Ghayn, Kha (7 letters)	Tongue back, throat open Vowels sound deeper/darker
Sometimes heavy sometimes light	Raa and Laam	Depends on surrounding vowels (see rules below)
Always LIGHT (Muraqqaq)	All other letters	Tongue relaxed Sound is thin/light

The Special Rule for Laam in ALLAH

The laam in the word Allah has a unique rule based on the VOWEL BEFORE IT:

• After Fatha or Damma → Laam is HEAVY

Example: Qaalal-LAAH (Allah after fatha)

Say: LAAH with deep, heavy sound

• After Kasra → Laam is LIGHT

Example: Bismillaah (after kasra)

Say: llaah with light, thin sound

Other Key Sifaat

Al-Hams (Whispered)

- Letters: 10 letters: Fa Ha Tha Ha Shin Kha Saad Seen Kaaf Ta
- Characteristic: Air escapes when pronounced — hold a piece of paper and feel it move

Al-Jahr (Voiced)

- Letters: All other 18 letters
- Characteristic: Vocal cords vibrate — sound is clear and resonant

Ash-Shidda (Strong)

- Letters: Hamza Jeem Daal Qaaf Taa Ba Kaaf Ta (8 letters)

- Characteristic: Sound stops completely — no air flows

Al-Qalqalah (Bouncing)

- Letters: Qaaf Taa Ba Jeem Daal (5 letters)
- Characteristic: A small bounce/echo when these letters have sukoon

Key Reminders

- ★ Sifaat explain WHY 28 letters need 28 distinct sounds even though some share a makhraj.
- ★ The 7 always-heavy letters are easy to memorize: just think of the word Khalq-Daad-Saad-Ghayn (■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■).
- ★ Listen to a Qari recite the Fatiha and notice how the heavy Saad in Al-Sirat sounds much deeper than the light letters around it.